

NOMAD

A Screenplay

EXT. INFINITY POOL – GOLDEN HOUR

Full frame, no context. Paradise. Water like poured glass, too perfect. A laugh on the soundtrack lands a half-beat late.

A single frame STUTTERS.

MAIN TITLE: NOMAD

INT. OFFICE SPACE – DAY

A floor at its midpoint. Bodies among empty desks. Nobody looks up.

CAIRNS (30s, loud, likeable) packs his desk into a printer-paper box, performing an exit for a floor that isn't watching. Only WILL and JOHN are.

CAIRNS

*(raising an invisible glass, to
the empty desks)*

To four incredible years. Truly.
Some of the best emails of my
life.

Nobody looks up. He toasts anyway.

A ROBOT BOSS – a monitor on a wheeled stand, running the boss's warm AI likeness – rolls up. Cairns puts a hand to his heart and gives it a review.

CAIRNS

Five stars. Would be exploited
again.

ROBOT BOSS

Thanks for the feedback!

A half-beat late. John and Will crack up.

INT. BOSS'S HOUSE – CONTINUOUS

The real boss, mid golf-sim swing. The office feed props against a lamp, unwatched.

INT. OFFICE SPACE – ELEVATOR BANK – CONTINUOUS

Will and John flank Cairns, carrying nothing. Happy for him. A little jealous.

Cairns brags about a SERVICE – handles everything, one fee – and can't answer a single follow-up. Nobody grills him.

Will and Cairns run their handshake. The dumb elaborate one. Fast, perfect, muscle memory.

The doors close on Cairns mid-sell.

A beat. John eyes Cairns' empty chair.

JOHN

I always liked that chair.

He drops into it, gives it a spin. Will cracks up despite himself.

INT. OFFICE SPACE – MOMENTS LATER

The floor, back at work. Cairns' chair, still faintly spinning. On the desk, a branded welcome folder.

SUPER: ONE YEAR LATER

INT. OFFICE SPACE – MORNING

The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence – a runway for nobody.

He passes dark departments. Cairns' desk, untouched, the folder gathering a year of dust.

At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot. Will pours its only cup.

INT. OFFICE SPACE – WILL'S DESK – DAY

A queue of faces. Machine verdicts. One button: APPROVE. Will clicks. A streak counter climbs.

A face, machine-verified 98%. Will stops. Replays three seconds – the man is asked about his childhood; his eyes go nowhere.

Will overrides: SYNTHETIC. The system concedes. His streak resets to zero. No one looks up.

On his monitor: SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 – TOP HUMAN PERFORMER.

To log back in, Will re-verifies himself – face to the camera, look left, look right.

INSERT - SCREEN IDENTITY: LOW CONFIDENCE – RETRY.

BACK TO SCENE. He sighs, does it again. VERIFIED. Routine.

Later. The dashboard, a river of decisions. Will spots a fraud he's sure of. INTERVENE.

His screen dims. A coaching module auto-plays – "Trusting Your Tools," a cheerful presenter who blinks at perfectly regular intervals. In the corner, the system clears his case without him.

His screen blinks – an incoming call cuts straight through the coaching module. CAIRNS, poolside, sun, abundance.

CAIRNS

You wouldn't believe this place.
Everything's two-for-one –
everything.

He lowers his voice like it's a secret.

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
 You know how long since I
 clicked approve on anything?
 Since anybody checked I was –
(waving it off)
 I don't even remember my own
 login, man.

Two GIRLS flank him. To each other, dry, not for Cairns:

GIRL 1
(in Spanish; subtitled)
 Two weeks here and he thinks
 he's a local.

GIRL 2
(in Spanish; subtitled)
 Give him a month. He'll own the
 building.

Cairns doesn't understand a word. Delighted:

CAIRNS (CONT'D)
 See? They love it here too.
 Anyway – you know I'm tight with
 Michelle. Say the word, you're
 set up by Friday.

The girls pull him from frame.

CAIRNS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
 Love you, buddy!

The screen stays on. The three run to the pool. Cairns
 throws one girl in.

Will watches. A tinge of jealousy in it.

JOHN (O.S.)
 Is that Cairns? Nice.

Will kills the tab and turns. John, holding six beers – for
 the two of them.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT – MINI-PUTT COURSE – LATER

The lights are on. Hole 7 uses the old CEO's office door as
 a ramp.

JOHN
 You know I've never even been
 out of the states?

WILL
 Neither had Cairns, till
 Tuesday.

JOHN
 Yeah, well. Some of us like it

here.

He doesn't sound sure of that. Will lines up a putt.

Then – who's Michelle? The Service was a company. Since when does it have a first name? Neither of them knows. They shrug it off.

Will sinks the putt, doesn't celebrate. Somewhere else entirely.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT – NIGHT

A facetime with family. A parent, bad connection, distracted. The call ends first from their side.

On his laptop, a real-estate listing: the family home, priced to sell. Everyone scattered. He scrolls past it.

His building – lockboxes on every door, rolling suitcases in the hall, a different set of strangers each weekend. He's the last person who actually lives on his floor.

He opens the Service page. The logo he's walked past on Cairns' dead desk for a year.

INT. SERVICE STOREFRONT – DAY

An office park. The Service sits between a vape shop and a notary. Brochure rack, folding chairs, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos.

A bored coordinator checks Will in like a dentist's office.

INSERT - PASSPORT A scanner's green line crosses it.

BACK TO SCENE. Face capture: look left, look right, read this aloud. Will jokes that he does this for a living.

COORDINATOR

Then you know it's painless.

The coordinator winks – a half-beat late.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)

One more. For the file –
describe your dream place. Take
your time.

WILL

(to camera, easy, unprompted)
High floor. Light in the
morning. Somewhere I don't have
to explain myself to anybody.

He means it as a throwaway. The camera keeps rolling a beat after he's done.

INT. WILL'S CAR – PARKING LOT – CONTINUOUS

The email arrives before he's out of the lot. MICHELLE – template-warm, exclamation points, a scheduling link.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT – NIGHT

Michelle's welcome preview: an automated ad starring WILL. His face, his walk, composited into Cairns' paradise. "See yourself there."

He watches himself live the ad, delighted. He says his name for the personalization. Says it again, excited. Grinning.

INSERT - SCREEN A checkbox fills: CONFIRM MY DETAILS. It plays his own face back to him – and for half a second his eyes look wrong.

BACK TO SCENE. He blames the compression.

INT. OFFICE SPACE – DAY

The ROBOT BOSS rolls to the center of the floor. An all-hands. On its screen: the real boss, on a treadmill somewhere sun-bleached, barely winded.

BOSS

(V.O., warm, unbothered)

Big news, team – the floor's closing! Full remote by end of October. Genuinely so excited for what's next.

A half-beat late, he raises a coconut water like a toast. The feed freezes on his smile a second too long, then cuts.

John's answer: the last day in the office is the MINI-PUTT CHAMPIONSHIP. He starts the bracket.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT – NIGHT

John helps Will pack. He finds Will's putter, tapes WILL on the grip, keeps it.

Will holds it up, half-laughing.

WILL

It's a putt-putt bracket, John.

JOHN

It's the last one.

It sits there. Will promises to be back for it. Half-listening.

INT. APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY – DAY

A viewing. Perfect. And not empty.

CAMILA (20s) and her family box up the place they've lived in for years. The Service is turning the building over to arrivals.

AGENT

Unit's just come available – they don't usually turn this

fast. You'd be moving in the
same week as the family moving
out.

Will sees it. He understands exactly what he's looking at.

AGENT (CONT'D)

Interested?

He takes it.

EXT. CAMILA'S BUILDING – NIGHT

Camila and her mother carry the last boxes down a stairwell
of keypad locks and strangers' suitcases.

She looks up at her own lit window – where a man she's
never met is already pouring a drink.

CAMILA

(in Spanish; subtitled)

He looks comfortable.

They keep walking.

EXT. MEXICO CITY – DAY

Will haggles a vendor down for sport. Overtips elsewhere to
feel generous. Lives entirely in English, always
accommodated. Charming. Oblivious.

He texts Cairns on landing. Cairns is warm, specific, flaky
– "in Oaxaca for a thing, next week for SURE, I already
told everyone you're here."

At a rooftop party, a flicker of familiarity – the light,
the pool, the shape of the night. He shrugs it off.

He passes two locals mid-conversation, subtitled for us –
about the building where the American who's never home
lives. The building sits behind them, unnoticed.

At the tail end of the block, a homeless man on the curb.
Gaunt, wrecked, mouth working – no sound comes out.

It's CAIRNS. His tongue is gone. He can't speak. Can't
warn, can't sell, can't say a name.

He reaches – not quite toward Will, just toward the street.
Will steps around him without looking, phone up, and is
gone.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY – NIGHT / INT. DEAD OFFICE – NIGHT

Will calls JOHN. Mini-putt updates from the dark floor.
Will poolside, pretending he isn't lonely at a party.

JOHN

Cairns liked my bracket post. So
he's in. So you better be in.

WILL

Course.

JOHN

It's gonna be everybody.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY – NIGHT

The poolside frame. Cairns, still selling, still "next week."

Will raises a fist to the webcam and starts their handshake. Muscle memory.

The likeness follows. It knows the handshake – but comes a half-beat late and lands one move wrong. The move the real Cairns never misses.

Same laugh, 0.4 off. It slides back into the sell without a seam.

Four seconds of Will fully awake. His hand still up. The call does not end. It goes on, pleasantly – Will managing a goodnight.

CAIRNS

I love you, man.

A half-beat late. Will closes the laptop and sits very still in the best apartment he's ever had.

INT. WILL'S APARTMENT, MEXICO CITY – NIGHT – LATER

Desk lamp. Blue screen light. Two video windows side by side: an old real Cairns clip and a recent call, each with a timestamp overlay. Will drags them frame by frame.

A call Cairns swore was "this morning" carries a UTC stamp that doesn't line up – the light's wrong, the background clock's wrong, the time zone's wrong. The laugh, isolated on a waveform: a half-second late.

Then the thing he's actually hunting for. He runs the call metadata. Every message from Cairns – every call, for months – pings the same coordinates. Will drops them on a map.

One building. He has the address because he found it.

EXT. CAIRNS' BUILDING – DAY

From below. Monolithic. It fills the frame.

He goes a day early. Cairns, finally, at a place he can walk to.

INT. CAIRNS' BUILDING – DAY

Mid-morning – the lobby's dead, the front desk mid shift-change. Will slips in behind a delivery cart, badge-less, unremarked. Nobody's watching the door; the cameras are watching the residents. The service stairs.

Upstairs: nothing. No set, no pool. An empty floor – chairs, capture rigs like the storefront's, racks of humming servers. A propped fire door, someone's cigarette break, forgotten.

Through it: the RENDER FARM. An operator types a line. A poolside evening assembles in seconds – Cairns' pool, water that has never been wet.

On another screen, a girl who doesn't exist is thrown laughing into it. A slider drags her laugh warmer.

On a third: familiar faces, likenesses at work, attending standups.

On one screen, mid-generation: WILL'S OWN welcome ad, refining. Him, poolside, saying things he's never said. The line about the high floor and the morning light plays back, exactly as he gave it.

From the next row – WILL'S OWN LAUGH. The real one. He follows his own voice.

The worst screen in the building: CAIRNS' LIKENESS on a call with WILL'S LIKENESS. Poolside together. Their in-jokes. Version numbers in the corner.

Will slips out. An operator clocks him in a doorway reflection, and doesn't care.

He heads for the stairwell – and finds it blocked. Building security, apologetic, procedural: anyone without a resident badge gets verified before they leave. Standard, since an incident with a tenant last month.

Will almost laughs. He wrote a version of this exact policy for a different building, a different company, a lifetime ago.

There's no way out he hasn't already used to get in. He goes where they point.

INT. DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT – DAY / INT. VERIFICATION ROOM – DAY – INT.

In the DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: last day. The floor half-dismantled – desks tagged, cables coiled, the coffee machine unplugged. A paper banner goes up. The bracket: one name crossed out, rewritten smaller – WILL (REMOTE?).

John, in a homemade referee shirt, by hole 7. Two beers. Will's putter leans against the hole. Reserved.

In the VERIFICATION ROOM: Will sits in the chair – good light, a liveness rig, the machinery he's used his whole career. He asks it to confirm who he is.

It reads the polished model as authentic. It flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. The examiner reads a number. The number is confident.

INSERT - SCREEN STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE.

Behind him, a wall of numbered lockers, most tagged. One readable: a first name, a version number.

An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet, clips it to Will's collar. Inventory now. A hand guides him, unhurried, toward a door – a specimen the model keeps to check itself against. He doesn't fight it. On paper, he isn't here.

The DEAD SALES DEPARTMENT: John's phone BUZZES.

A message from "Will." He can't make the championship – but John's gotta get out of there, come down HERE, he'll set him up.

We never see the screen. Only John, lit by it.

John does not smile. Something crosses his face – not delight, not alarm. Something he can't place. The rhythm's a little off. The warmth's a shade too smooth. For one second he almost catches it.

Then, slowly, uncertainly, he starts to type back.

A single frame stutters – almost too fast to catch.

We stay on John. His face, lit by the phone. The putter reserved behind him. Hold.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END